

European steppe

The steppe is a temperate grassland habitat. Many animals here are seasonal visitors from other habitats, while some, such as hamsters and moles, live here all year round.

Black-bellied hamster

This hamster digs summer and fall burrows 19½ in (50 cm) below the ground's surface. Its winter burrow can be 6½ ft (2 m) deep.

When swimming, this hamster inflates its cheek pouches to act like water wings!



Black fur on its underside gives the black-bellied hamster its name.



HABITAT KEY

- Temperate grasslands
- Coniferous forests
- Scrublands
- Deciduous forests
- Mountains

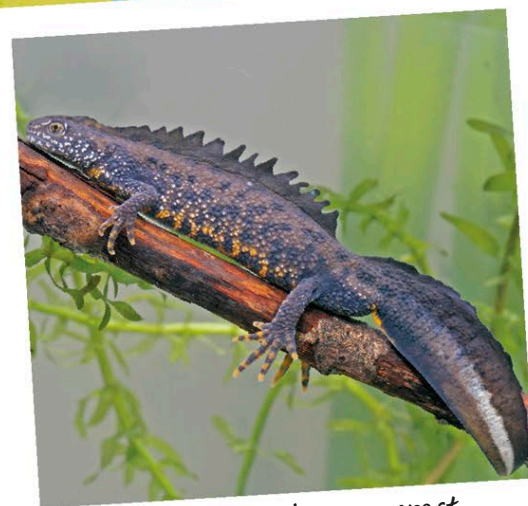
Location

The European steppe stretches from Romania in the west to the Ural Mountains in the east, where it merges with the Asian steppe.



Common nightingale

This little bird is plain to look at, but its song sets it apart. Nightingale songs have high and low notes, phrases, and trills that other birds can't make.



Only males have a crest on their backs.

Northern crested newt

Also called the great crested newt, this amphibian gets up to 6½ in (17 cm) long. Newts are most active at night, and spend the day hiding in ponds, or under damp logs or rocks.